



Last dance: At the Paris Games, 42-year-old Sharath Kamal competed in his fifth and final Olympics. He was also India's flag bearer for the opening ceremony. AP

Indian contingent alongside P. V. Sindhu at the Opening Ceremony of Paris 2024. How did he handle the burden of the expectations of 1.4 billion people?

Being a flagbearer is a humbling honour for Sharath. Paddler Ma Long was the joint-flagbearer for China. Every Olympic Games, we have had a couple of table tennis players be flagbearers; it's good for TT.

There are big expectations from every player. I've played in the Olympics. I coached Italy before. Expectations are there. You have to face the reality. Other players too face the same. Sometimes, you make the mistake of thinking that the outcome is only in your hands. Our performance is always dependent on the opponent, and we have to accept that. We have to accept when we do

well and accept when others also do well.

I kept my expectations low. I don't want to expect a lot and get super disappointed, thinking I didn't achieve anything. Every player must have low expectations and see how they must gain every point. That's what happened with the women when we played against Romania. We succeeded at first. When we started to play against Germany, one would have expected us to make the semifinals or even get the medal. But Germany is better than us. That's the bottom line.

Sharath said Paris was his last Olympics. Do you think it was the

right moment to call it a day?

Sharath is a monument and an institution for Indian TT. He will always be supporting the fraternity. His wisdom and experience are our legacy. Whoever is taking his place can only learn to treasure his results, personality, and whatever he did in his career.

I thank him for whatever he has done. I had even worked with him at the 2010 Commonwealth Games, when he won the gold medal in doubles with Subhagit Saha. The cycles work like that. Sometimes, when careers end, we have to accept them. I've learnt a lot from him.

A new chapter is coming. I wish him good luck. I hope he will

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